Court

Bind and Devour

A game of social intrigue and infernal peerage



Overview

- Your **true name** is made of 4 secret **name tokens**. The dots on them decide your name and your **role**.
- At the start of the game every token goes into a bag. On your turns you spend **souls** to draw tokens and event cards.
- Tokens are kept face down. Everyone can see their colors, but only the holder knows their dots.
- When you hold the most of someone's tokens, you may **name** them. Guess right and you **bind** them (they serve you) or **devour** them (they're out). Guess wrong and *they* decide your fate.
- **You win** when every other player has been devoured or is your thrall.

Components

- **Name tokens**: 4 per player color, each marked with 1, 2, 3 or 4 dots. The color shows on both sides; the dots only on one. Spare tokens (or blank tokens and a dry-erase marker) are used for Rebirth.
- **Event cards**: a deck of 48.
- **Souls**: the currency, kept in a bank.
- One opaque **bag**, one **slip** of paper per player, and the **name table** (page 9).

Setup

1. Each player takes the 4 tokens of their color and secretly chooses dot values for them: any mix of 1–4, repeats allowed. That combination is your true name. There are 35 possible names; two players may choose the same one.
2. Write your combination on your slip and keep it face down. You'll reveal it if someone names you.
3. Work out your role (below). Keep it secret.
4. Put *all* players' tokens into the bag and shake it.
5. Shuffle the event cards into a face-down deck.
6. Give everyone 2 souls. Roll a die to see who goes first. Play passes **counterclockwise**.

Your Role

Add up the dots on your 4 tokens and divide by 5. The *remainder* is your role.

Remainder	Role	Dot totals
0	Archduke	5, 10, 15
1	Duke	6, 11, 16
2	Prince	7, 12
3	Marquis	8, 13
4	Earl	4, 9, 14

> *You choose 1, 2, 3, 4. The total is 10, which leaves remainder 0, so you are an Archduke. The name table says your true name is Beleth.*

Each role has exactly 7 names. Using your role's power tells everyone which 7 names you might have, so choose when to use it.

Your Turn

On Your Turn

1. **Income.** Take 2 souls from the bank. (A thrall's 2 souls go straight to their binder.)
2. **Act**, in any order and as often as allowed:
   - Buy **1** name token, if it's a token round (see below).
   - Buy event cards for **1 soul each**, as many as you like.
   - Play event cards, use your role's ability, and trade.

Naming can happen at *any* time, even on another player's turn.

Buying Name Tokens

You may buy at most one name token per turn, in one of two ways:

- **1 soul**: draw 1 random token from the bag.
- **3 souls**: draw 2 tokens without looking at their dots, keep 1 by its color, and return the other unseen.

Look at the dots of a token once it's yours, then place it in front of you dot side down.

Token Rounds

Until the bag has been emptied once, name tokens can only be bought in **odd rounds** (1, 3, 5, ...). The Scrying card follows the same rule. After the bag first runs empty, tokens can be bought every round.

No Limits

There's no limit on how many souls you can spend in a turn, or how many souls and cards you can hold. If the event deck runs out, shuffle the used cards into a new deck.

Naming

Naming is how demons fall. It's the heart of the game.

Who May Name a Player

You may try to name a player if you hold **at least 1** of their tokens and **nobody else holds more**.

- The target's own tokens don't count.
- If players are tied for the most, each of them may try.
- If nobody besides the target holds any of their tokens, **anyone** may try. (Hoarding your own name doesn't make you safe.)
- Tokens held by thralls count too.

How to Name

1. Announce whether you will **bind** or **devour** if you're right.
2. Say the name (or combination) you think they have.
3. The target reveals their slip.

If you're right, you bind or devour them, as you announced.
If you're wrong, it backfires: *they* choose whether to bind or devour *you*.

> *Ana holds 2 of Ben's red tokens; Cal holds 1. Ana holds the most, so she may name Ben. Her two tokens show 1 and 2, and she suspects Ben is a Prince. She announces "devour" and guesses Sitri (1123). If Ben's slip says 1123, Ana devours him. If it says anything else, Ben decides whether to bind Ana or devour her.*

Rules that Always Apply

- A **Prince** can only bind, never devour (except a Marquis; see Roles).
- A **Marquis** can only devour, and can never be bound.
- You may never hint at or reveal what's on your tokens. You are encouraged to lie about everything else, except when answering an Archduke's question.

Bind or Devour?

	Bind	Devour
Target	Stays in the game as your **thrall**	Is out of the game
You take	All their event cards and souls, plus 1 of their tokens, which you choose by color, face down	All their event cards and souls, plus half their tokens (rounded up), which you choose by color, face down
Bonus	Their 2 souls each turn, forever	4 souls from the bank (not if they were your thrall)
Their other tokens	Stay with them	Go back into the bag

When a player is devoured, every token of their color is removed from the game, wherever it is.

Giving away taken tokens. Right after you bind or devour someone, before you look at the name tokens you took, you may give any of them away, face down, to players who aren't thralls. No trade fee is paid, since you never saw them. You can devour your own thrall on any of your turns.

Thralls

- Thralls still take turns, but any souls they would get go straight to their binder.
- Thralls can't name anyone, except with an Arrogation card.
- Thralls can't trade.
- Thralls can't be named, so no one can take them from their binder. If a binder is bound or devoured, their thralls pass to whoever did it.

Trading

On your turn you may trade souls, event cards and name tokens with anyone who isn't a thrall.

- Name tokens are expensive to trade: for *each* token, the giver and the receiver each pay 4 souls to the bank.
- Tokens and cards pass face down. The table sees a token's color, not its dots.
- Promises are not binding unless sealed with a Pact.

Roles

Role	Power
Archduke	Force any player to truthfully answer one yes-or-no question. Once per player. Can't question other players' thralls.
Duke	While holding an Arrogation card, gains the Archduke's question, usable on up to half of the other starting players (rounded down) over the whole game.
Prince	Can only bind, except against a Marquis. May buy name tokens from their own thralls for 2 souls each (paid to the bank).
Marquis	Can't bind and can't be bound. See below.
Earl	May take 1 free event card on each of their turns, if they want.

The Marquis

Because a Marquis can't be bound, naming one works differently.

- Once anyone except a Prince names a Marquis correctly, the Marquis is **marked** and keeps playing. From then on, any player except a Prince may devour the Marquis by paying 4 souls.
- When that happens, the Marquis's cards, souls and tokens, and the 4-soul devour bonus, go to whoever *originally* named them (or, if that player has been devoured, to whoever devoured them).
- If a **Prince** names a Marquis correctly, or gets to decide a Marquis's fate (for example, the Marquis names the Prince wrongly, or breaks a Pact with them), the Prince devours the Marquis at once.

Event Cards

Card	Copies	Effect
Seize	12	Discard 2 to steal 1 event card from anyone. Discard 4 to steal a random face-down token of a chosen color from anyone.
Collect	6	Cash in at any time for 2 souls.
Scrying	6	Draw a name token from the bag, or dig through the event deck. See below.
Ward	9	Used in sets of 3 to delay being bound or devoured. See below.
Pact	3	Make a binding deal with another player, or with yourself. See below.
Arrogation	4	When drawn: the Duke's power, or a thrall's chance to rebel. Can be traded or stolen like any card. See below.
Welfare	6	When drawn, reveal it. The poorest player who isn't a thrall takes 1 soul from every other player who has souls. Net worth = souls + event cards + 2 × name tokens. Players tied for poorest split the souls; an extra soul goes to the second-poorest.
Meta	2	When drawn, you must immediately verbally/physically assault a player of your choice.

Scrying

Choose one:

- Draw 3 tokens from the bag without seeing their dots, keep 1 by color, and return the rest unseen. Token rounds only; counts as your token purchase that turn.
- Discard 2 Scrying cards to look at the top 4 event cards. Any "when drawn" card among them takes effect and doesn't count. Keep 2 of the others; discard the rest.

Pact

Write a deal with another player, or with yourself, and propose it; the card waits in front of you.

- With another player: takes effect when they accept.
- With yourself: takes effect when every other player approves. The terms must say who gets your souls, event cards, name tokens and thralls if you break it; only players who aren't thralls can receive.
- If anyone rejects it, the card returns to your hand. Once it takes effect, discard it.

Kept or broken is decided when every player still in the game but one agrees, and never fewer than two (with two left, both). Thralls vote; devoured players don't. For a deal between two players, they must also agree who broke it.

- Break a deal with another player: they choose to bind or devour you.
- Break a Pact with yourself: you are devoured, your things go where the terms said, and every token of your color leaves the game.
- Ward can delay either.

Thralls can't make or join Pacts, but they vote. A Pact is void once a party is bound or devoured; a card still waiting goes back to its proposer if they're still free.

Ward

When you would be bound or devoured because of a correct naming, a paid devour of you as a marked Marquis, or a broken Pact, you may discard 3 Wards. It waits until the end of your next turn; discard 3 more then to delay it again. Meanwhile you play normally, but no one else may name you or pay to devour you.

If the player claiming you is bound or devoured first, the claim passes to whoever did it, and they choose bind or devour (following role limits). If you take out that player yourself, by any means, the claim ends, and if you had been named, you are reborn (see Rebirth).

A broken Pact with yourself has no claimant: Ward only delays it. Ward doesn't work against your own wrong guess, and doesn't stop a Marquis from being marked.

Arrogation and Rebirth

When drawn, do the first of these that applies:

1. **You're a Duke:** you may keep it. While you hold it, you have the Archduke's question, usable on up to half of the other starting players (rounded down) over the whole game.
2. **A thrall could use it:** show it and give it to a thrall of your choice. They may try to name their binder without holding the most of the binder's tokens.
    - **If they succeed**, they trade places (the binder becomes their thrall, and the old binder's other thralls follow) and they are **reborn**: they secretly choose a new name (any combination except the old one) and take its role, and every one of their old tokens, in hands and in the bag, is swapped one for one for a random token of the new name.
    - **If they fail**, they give their binder all their name tokens and can never use Arrogation against that binder again.
3. **Otherwise:** put it back anywhere in the deck, or discard it.

If you get it any other way (a trade, Seize, or taking someone's cards), you simply hold it.

Name Table

Combinations are written smallest dots first; the order of your tokens doesn't matter. Within each role, names are in the order they appear in the Ars Goetia.

Name	Combination	Total	Role
Bael	1112	5	Archduke
Paimon	1144	10	Archduke
Beleth	1234	10	Archduke
Purson	1333	10	Archduke
Asmoday	2224	10	Archduke
Balam	2233	10	Archduke
Belial	3444	15	Archduke
Agares	1113	6	Duke
Valefor	1122	6	Duke
Barbatos	1244	11	Duke
Gusion	1334	11	Duke
Eligos	2234	11	Duke
Astaroth	2333	11	Duke
Gremory	4444	16	Duke
Vassago	1114	7	Prince
Sitri	1123	7	Prince
Ipos	1222	7	Prince
Gaap	1344	12	Prince
Stolas	2244	12	Prince
Orobas	2334	12	Prince
Seere	3333	12	Prince
Samigina	1124	8	Marquis
Amon	1133	8	Marquis
Leraje	1223	8	Marquis
Naberius	2222	8	Marquis
Forneus	1444	13	Marquis
Shax	2344	13	Marquis
Andras	3334	13	Marquis
Botis	1111	4	Earl
Marax	1134	9	Earl
Furfur	1224	9	Earl
Halphas	1233	9	Earl
Raum	2223	9	Earl
Bifrons	2444	14	Earl
Andromalius	3344	14	Earl